gathered and we were ready to start summing up the problem, outlining the demands made by conflicting criteria and the various positions presented by opposing interests and making our recommendations for action. I also realised that this tended to happen on days that were relatively quiet in the office, with no crises or meetings. Such spel s increased steadily in frequency, and the SLV-3 dream was final y realised in the middle of 1979.

We had scheduled the first experimental flight trial of SLV-3 for 10 August 1979. The primary goals of the mission were to realise a ful y integrated launch vehicle; to evaluate on-board systems like stage motors, guidance and control systems and electronic subsystems; and to evaluate ground systems, like checkout, tracking, telemetry and real-time data facilities in launch operations built at the Sriharikota launch complex. The 23 metre-long, four-stage SLV rocket weighing 17 tonnes final y took off elegantly at 0758 hours and immediately started fol owing its programmed trajectory.

Stage I performed to perfection. There was a smooth transition from this stage to the second stage. We were spel bound to see our hopes flying in the form of the SLV-3.